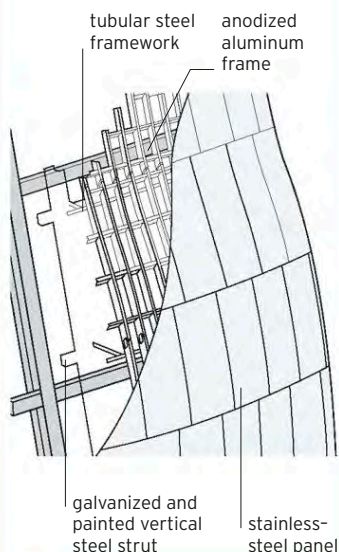


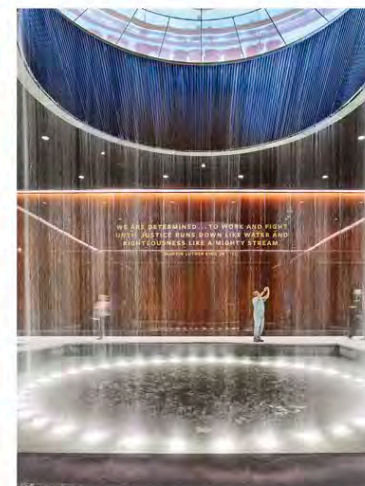
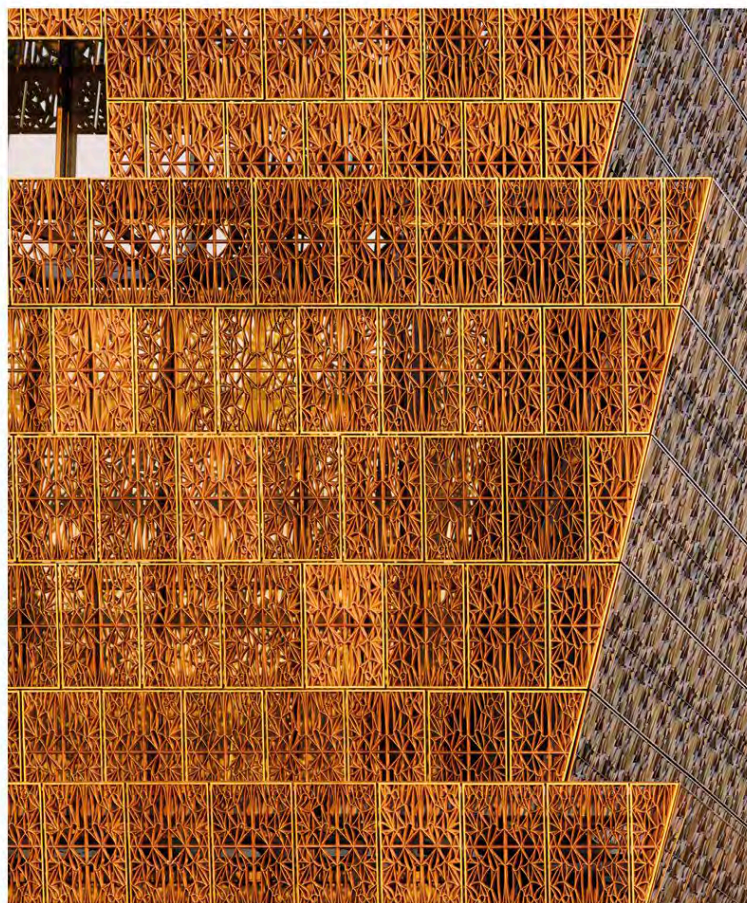
OUTER SHELL

More than 12,500 individual pieces of stainless steel were used to create the complex curves that wrap around the concert hall, and no two are the same. Glass and stone were used in the more conventional parts of the building.



SKIN OF STEEL

The flamboyant stainless-steel exterior encloses a concert hall with seating for 2,265 people, as well as restaurants, an exhibition space, and other rooms.



THE CONTEMPLATIVE COURT

The Contemplative Court is a space for visitors to reflect on the often painful exhibits in the museum. A cylindrical fountain rains down water into the square pool below.

SYMBOLIC PATTERNS

The exterior of the building is covered with a thin, bronze-colored aluminum lattice—a homage to the skilled ironwork crafted by enslaved African Americans.

National Museum of African American History and Culture

A building that imaginatively brings together elements of cultural expression from Africa and the Americas



The Civil War (1861–1865) might have ended slavery, but its bitter legacy lived on for years. In 1915, a group of African American veterans of the Union Army that fought in that war met for a reunion, bemoaning the racial discrimination they still faced. They formed a committee to build a memorial to African American achievements, receiving approval in 1929 from President Hoover (1874–1964). Progress was slow, and opposition fierce, until the Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of African American History and Culture, situated proudly on the National Mall in Washington, D.C., was finally opened on September 24, 2016, by the nation's first black president, Barack Obama (1961–). The museum houses more than 37,000 exhibits celebrating African American history.

The building's dramatic shape—a three-tiered inverted pyramid—was inspired by the form of the crowns worn by Yoruban rulers in West Africa and mirrors the angles evident in the capstone of the nearby Washington Monument (see p.30). The exterior is covered by a corona made of 3,600 bronze-colored metal panels.

Sustainable future

Visitors enter from the National Mall through a sweeping porch into a huge central hall that offers expansive views to the upper and lower levels—60 percent of the museum's volume is below ground. The building was constructed from locally sourced or salvaged materials and incorporates the best practices of green design in order to reduce its power and water consumption.

